

One final shot for Neymar

There has been a lot of debate over whether Neymar Jr. should be part of Brazil's hunt for a sixth World Cup trophy. And despite not playing for the Selecao since October 2023, the winger himself has insisted that he is fit and ready, even orchestrating a move to his boyhood club Santos (**below**) in an effort to shake off the rust.

And his efforts have not gone unnoticed, as Carlo Ancelotti has named the 34-year-old in his squad for what may well be his last dance. Despite being Brazil's all-time leading scorer with 79 goals, Neymar has never lifted the World Cup — a fact that makes him an outlier among the titans of his nation. So even if a speck of magic remains in his legs, it is only fair that one of the greatest players of this generation gets one final shot at glory.

Meanwhile, Ancelotti has extended his contract as Brazil head coach until the 2030 FIFA World Cup, giving the five-time champion stability beyond this year's tournament.

The 66-year-old Italian, one of the most decorated managers in club football, will lead Brazil at the 2026 World Cup in the United States, Canada and Mexico, where it has been drawn in Group C alongside Morocco, Haiti and Scotland. The extension comes as Brazil looks to end its World Cup drought, having last won the title in 2002.



Relief measures

The build-up to the 2026 FIFA World Cup in the United States has seen two fan-facing policy changes, with New Jersey reducing rail fares for matchgoers and the Trump administration easing visa bond rules for some foreign ticket holders.

Officials said the latest reduction was made possible through additional advertising revenue and would not add costs for regular commuters.

NJ Transit has cut round-trip rail fares to the New York-New Jersey Stadium, which will host the final, to USD 98 after criticism over an earlier USD 150 proposal. The fare had first been reduced to USD 105 before being lowered again.

Meanwhile, the US State Department has said World Cup ticket holders from five qualified countries — Algeria, Cape Verde, Ivory Coast, Senegal and Tunisia — will not have to pay visa bonds of up to USD 15,000. The exemption applies to eligible fans who bought tickets and used the FIFA Pass system for prioritised visa appointments.

The measures offer relief to fans, though travel rules, visa processing and affordability remain key concerns.



China secures broadcast

Football fans in China heaved a sigh of relief after the nation managed to strike a World Cup broadcast deal with FIFA.

The agreement covers the next four World Cups — two men's and two women's tournaments — through to 2031. Meanwhile, with less than a month until the opening kick-off, India is yet to seal a deal due to differences over pricing.

